

CIRCLE OF LIFE
Raina with RRF students in Delhi

ROBIN RAINA FOUNDATION
FOUNDED: 2003
Charity organisation

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"Everything you have can go way in a micro-second. The act of giving is the only thing that will remain"

— ROBIN RAINA
Founder-CEO, Ebix

Education as a tool to break intergenerational poverty is a key focus area for Raina and his charity organisation—the Robin Raina Foundation (RRF). He has adopted over 3,500 children to date through multiple educational initiatives. His first project came about when the Delhi government relocated 150,000 people during the Commonwealth Games to Bawana. "In 2005, when I visited the area, I saw people living in huts, with hazards all around—all to make the city 'clean'," says Raina, who proceeded to set up a school in the area. But he soon discovered that every five to six months, children would drop out as their parents kept shifting around the city in search of work and home. "I then had an idea—what if I build concrete legal homes for them? Then they would not have to move and their children could receive a permanent and stable education," says Raina. He made a commitment to build 6,000 homes, of which 2,304 have been handed over. Each home has a concrete roof, a solid brick foundation of four feet, a kitchen, an exhaust fan, electricity, power and gas with a meter connection. He builds each at a cost of Rs 1 lakh, but hands them over free of cost. However, he places two conditions via a legal agreement with the new homeowner—the house cannot be sold for the first seven years and the children, particularly girls, must be sent to school.

The RRF also invested in the medical care of the elderly in the area. "I am 85 years old and suffer from multiple health problems," says Najmun Nisha, owner of plot no. 205 in Bawana. "Not only did RRF build me a permanent home but it also gives me Rs 1,000 a month for food and medicines,"

Those fortunate enough to be in RRF's schools and vocational training centres in Bawana have a bright future to look forward to. "Earlier, I just loitered in the streets with no real hope or ambition, but now with my education at RRF, I feel I stand a chance to have a good future," says Shamm (*name changed*), a class 6 student at the RRF School in Bawana.

Raina, a Kashmiri Hindu, also wanted to stress through his charity choices that geography or politics place no limits on help. Ward no. 224 at Imran Khan's Shaukat Khanum Cancer Hospital in Lahore is named after Raina; he sponsors the treatment of three children at any given point.

Technology can do wonders for the future of charity, particularly when it comes to transparency. "Many times I felt people didn't donate because they didn't know what happened to their donation," says Raina. He has recently started the Yogdaan project along with the NGO Sewa Bharti. It uses barcodes to keep track of every donation and instant text messages to let the donor know what is happening with it. "We take donations that are usable—books, clothes, toys, and so on. And we sell them for Rs 5 each at our shop for the underprivileged in Ashok Vihar. As soon as someone buys it, the donor gets a notification," says Raina.

With so many initiatives in his name, Raina says it has helped him feel more grounded as a human being. Wanting to inspire others, he often posts about the benefits of giving to others for his 1.65 million social media fans. "Everything you have can go away in a micro-second. We think we are so powerful when we're alive, but anything can change. The coffin doesn't have a pocket and so you need to realise the only thing you can take with you is the act of giving," reflects Raina. Charity is his prayer and source of happiness. ■